

Another consideration suggests itself—if, as reported, the Diocletian campaign was most fierce and effective in the Byzantine area, the numerical advantage of the ‘Byzantine’ text-type over the ‘Western’ and ‘Alexandrian’ would have been reduced, giving the latter a chance to forge ahead. But it did not happen. The Church, in the main, refused to propagate those forms of the Greek text.

What we find upon consulting the witnesses is just such a picture. We have the Majority Text (Aland), or the Traditional Text (Burgon), dominating the stream of transmission with a few individual witnesses going their idiosyncratic ways. In Chapter 4 of my *Identity IV* I demonstrate that the notion of ‘text-types’ and recensions, as defined and used by Hort and his followers, is gratuitous. Epp’s notion of ‘streams’ fares no better. There is just one stream (actually a river), with a number of small eddies along the edges.<sup>1</sup> When I say the Majority Text dominates the stream, I mean it is represented in about 95% of the MSS.<sup>2</sup>

Actually, such a statement is not altogether satisfactory because it does not allow for the mixture or shifting affinities encountered within individual MSS. A better, though more cumbersome, way to describe the situation would be something like this: 100% of the MSS agree as to, say, 50% of the Text; 99% agree as to another 40%; over 95% agree as to another 4%; over 90% agree as to another 2%; over 80% agree as to another 2%; only for 2% or so of the Text do less than 80% of the MSS agree, and a disproportionate number of those cases occur in Revelation.<sup>3</sup>

---

N.T.” in Chapter 6 of my book, *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV.*, available from Amazon.com as well as from my site, [www.prunch.org](http://www.prunch.org).

<sup>1</sup> One might speak of a P<sup>45</sup>, W eddy or a P<sup>75</sup>, B eddy, for example.

<sup>2</sup> Although I used, of necessity, the term ‘text-type’ in some of my writings, I view the Majority Text as being much broader. It is a textual tradition which might be said to include a number of related ‘text-types’, such as von Soden’s K<sup>a</sup>, K<sup>i</sup>, and K<sup>l</sup>. I wish to emphasize again that it is only agreement in error that determines genealogical relationships. It follows that the concepts of ‘genealogy’ and ‘text-type’ are irrelevant with reference to original readings—they are only useful (when employed properly) for identifying spurious readings. Well, if there is a family that very nearly reflects the original its ‘profile’ or mosaic of readings will distinguish it from all other families, but most of those readings will not be errors (the competing variants distinctive of other families will be errors).

<sup>3</sup> I am not prepared to defend the precise figures used, they are **guesses**, but I believe they represent a reasonable approximation to reality. I heartily agree with Colwell when he insists that we must “rigorously eliminate the singular reading” (“External Evidence and New Testament Criticism”, *Studies in the History of the Text of the New Testament*, ed. B.L. Daniels and M.J. Suggs [Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1967], p. 8) on the altogether reasonable assumption (it seems to me) that a solitary witness against the world cannot possibly be right.